

HEMANT MISHRA

demonstrating blackhead removal, and comparing lip balms by texture and tint. The comment sections of male skincare influencers like Ankush Bahuguna (@wingitwithankush) and Allen Choudhary (@allen_choudhary)—both in the million-follower bracket—are filled with men asking questions such as: "Is this too dewy for oily skin?", "Will this match my wheatish tone?", or "Is it office-safe?".

"When men see other men on social media casually talking about their skincare routine, the products they use, and the science behind retinol vs niacinamide vs goji berry extract, it normalises it in their minds," says Malavika Sharma, an advertising professional. "Immediately after that, targeted Instagram ads create the opportunity to buy." The openness online is reflected offline, too. Influencers now film inside salons and dermatology clinics, normalising services like dermaplaning, chemical peels, brow shaping, blackhead extraction, wine facials, hydra facials and rose-scented scrubs for men. Barbershops post 'men's facial menu' highlights.

BREAKING STEREOTYPES

Even dermatologists have joined the bandwagon, hosting Q&A sessions on male skincare. They emphasise that it is unfair to expect men to use the same products as women. "Male skin has a higher density of oil glands and more hair follicles, leading to more acne, and bulkier face muscles, leading to more wrinkles," says Dr Rajat Kandhari, vice president and honorary secretary of the Delhi chapter of the Indian Association of Dermatology. Managing oil production, protecting collagen and maintaining the skin barrier—which gets stressed owing to repeated shaving—therefore becomes essential for men, he adds.

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>
> **SUNNY VALMIKI**
> **Skincare influencer**

But the evolution is uneven. Stereotypes persist—especially in conservative work cultures and smaller towns. As 40-year-old software engineer Ravindra Bansal (name changed), discovered. After following jewellery creators online, he finally bought a thin silver chain and a geometric ring. "I felt like myself for the first time," he says. But within weeks, colleagues teased him about "trying to be a hero". HR sent him a mail about 'appearance not aligning with workplace expectations'. A month later, he was dismissed under 'restructuring'. "It pushed me into a very dark place," Bansal says. "Friends told me I should have known better. I felt humiliated."

Psychiatrist Dr Srikanth Srinivasan, chief medical director at mental healthcare platform Niyama Digital Healthcare, says such stories reflect a widespread tension. "Indian men are raised with a rigid blueprint of masculinity—unemotional, restrained, always strong. Anything soft or expressive, from grooming to jewellery, is seen as weakness," he says. However, he sees the beginnings of change: "Younger men are questioning why self-care should be gendered."

Being more fluid around gender norms via make-up allows men to destigmatise the taboo of emotional vulnerability. Valmiki has noticed the uptick in confidence among men when they start focusing on their appearance. "A few years ago, if a guy mentioned serum, people would stare. Now you see men talking openly about skincare, mental health, therapy and burnout. That's powerful," he says. And there is no reason why that should be only a woman's reserve. Boys wanna be beautiful too. ■